NEIGHBOURS
INDIA-NEPAL

INDIAN ARMY FACES THE GORKHA QUESTION

THE PANDEMIC AND NEPAL'S OPPOSITION TO THE AGNIPATH SCHEME HAVE STALLED GORKHA RECRUITMENT IN THE INDIAN ARMY. THEIR FALLING NUMBERS ARE A STRATEGIC CONCERN FOR INDIA, PARTICULARLY AMIDST RISING SPECULATION ABOUT CHINESE PLANS TO INDUCT THE LEGENDARY SOLDIERS



BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

AMONG ETHNIC COMMUNITIES WITH A GLOBAL REPUTATION FOR THEIR QUALITIES as soldiers, the Gorkhas of Nepal occupy the highest rank. Like the Highlanders of Scotland, Gorkha soldiers are celebrated for their exemplary courage under fire, devotion to duty and fierce loyalty. Ever since the Gorkhas started being recruited over 200 years ago into the East India Company's army, the British Indian Army, and then, after 1947, into the Indian and British armies, they have won battle honours and gallantry awards practically everywhere they were deployed, including in the two world wars and in each war independent India has fought. A pillar of the Indian army, around 32,000 Gorkhas (39 battalions) are currently part of the seven Gorkha regiments of the Indian army. They include both Nepal-domiciled Gorkhas as well as India-domiciled Gorkha soldiers. Nepali Gorkhas constitute about 60 per cent of each battalion. However, their numbers in the Indian army have been steadily depleting, and no Gorkhas from Nepal—the only foreign nation whose men are part of the Indian army—have been recruited in the past four years.

Though the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020